

The Protector

Do this one in the first day or two of the week, after a sit. Plan on thirty to forty-five minutes. Keep it. You'll bring a piece of it to your Integration and Next-Step Session.

When you first turn toward what's been firing in your body, the first thing you meet usually isn't the tender thing. It's the protection. The clamp around the ribs. The band across the chest. The metal feeling in the gut. Something that says, in body language, I have to handle this. This journal is for meeting that piece on the page, in small doses, the way the practice asks you to in real life.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Take five minutes of breath first. The straw breath, five in, seven out. Let your shoulders drop. Let your jaw soften. When you've arrived, open your eyes and begin.

1. THE MOMENT

One moment from the last week or two that still has charge when you bring it to mind. A conversation, an email, a look, a silence. Two or three sentences. Not the whole story. Just enough to bring it back into the room with you.



2. THE BODY NOW

Close your eyes and let the moment come back. Don't replay the whole thing. Just let the image arrive.

Now drop your attention into your body. Notice what's happening right now, as you sit with the memory. Where is something present? Chest, throat, gut, jaw, shoulders. What's the quality? Heat, pressure, tightness, a hollow place, a flutter, something heavy, something hard. Don't analyze. Just report.



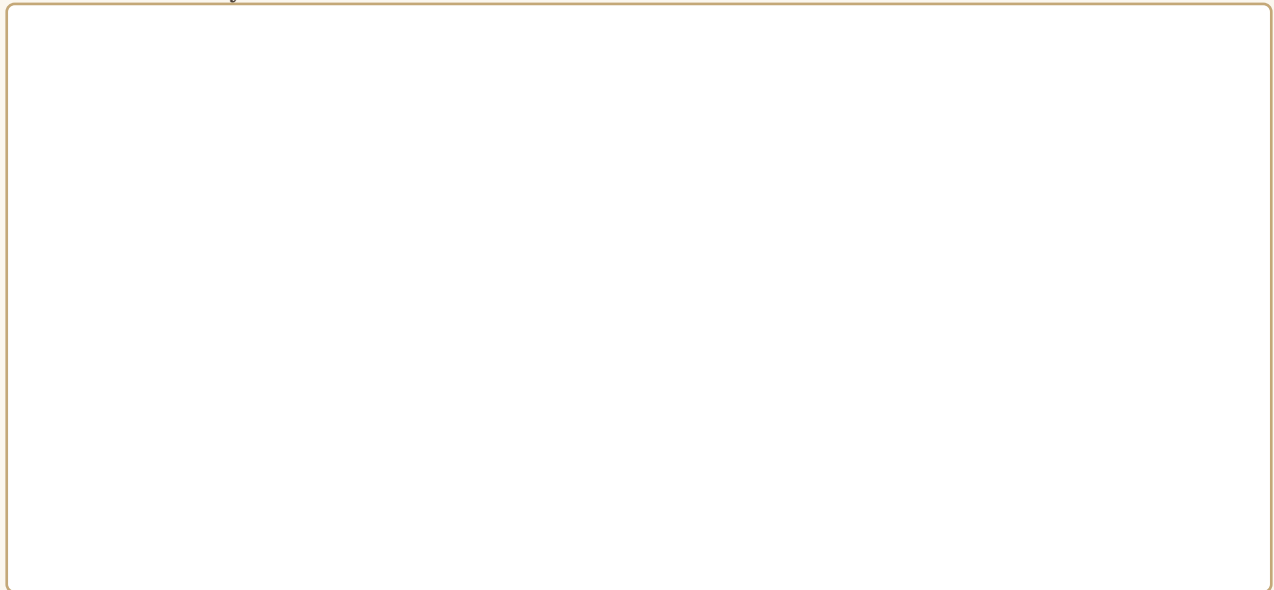
3. THE PROTECTOR

Look at what you just wrote. Is there a sensation that feels hard, or guarded? A band. A clamp. A wall of bracing. A piece of you that's holding the rest of you together.

Describe it. Where exactly is it? What's its shape? If you had to give it a texture, what is it: glass, metal, stone, ice, leather, something else?

If it could talk, what would it say? Usually it's simple. I have to handle this. I can't let them see. If I let go, I'll fall apart.

And which kid is this? The strong one, the fixer, the one who scans the room, the critic, the one who says I'm fine. Give it the name that fits.



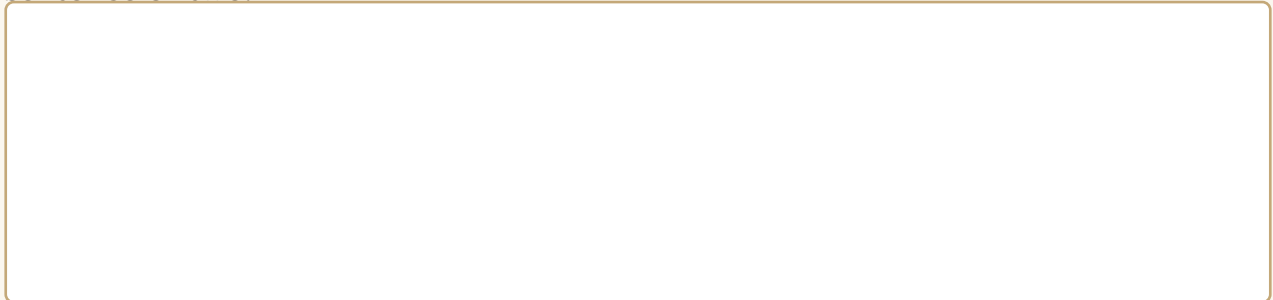
4. THREE PASSES

This is the rhythm of the practice. You touch the sensation for a short moment, you back off and rest your attention somewhere neutral, you come back. Little sips, not gulps. Do it three times here.

Pass one. Bring your attention to the protector. Stay with it for thirty seconds, no more. Then back off. Let your attention rest on the breath, your hands, the sound of the room, for thirty seconds. Then a sentence or two: what was it like under your attention, and what was it like to back off?



Pass two. Come back. Thirty seconds. Notice if anything has shifted. Back off again. A sentence or two.



Pass three. Come back one more time, and this time let your attention be softer. Not gripping, not analyzing, just keeping it company, the way you'd sit with a friend having a hard day. Forty-five seconds or a minute. Then back off. What did you notice on this pass?



5. WHAT SOFTENED

Scan the body again. What's there now?

The protector might have loosened. It might have stayed the same. It might have gotten louder before it settled. All of that is fine. It loosens when it senses safety, not when it's forced.

If something softened, describe what's underneath it. Often when the hard piece loosens, what's there is more tender. A scared place. An ache. Sometimes a younger version of you.

If nothing softened, describe what's still holding. What's the protector still doing? What does it still feel it needs to keep doing? Either way, write what's there now.



TO CARRY INTO THE WEEK

One line. The protector's word for itself, or the thing underneath it, or the pass where something changed. That's what you'll bring to the body this week.